



5 Productive skills: the opinion or argumentative essay (HL)

Productive skills · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The opinion essay is a Higher Level text type requiring a clear thesis, logically ordered paragraphs each built around one main argument supported by reasoning or example, and formal-to-semi-formal register with cohesive linking devices such as moreover, however and consequently. Unlike a blog post, it maintains a consistent, argument-focused stance and should acknowledge at least one counter-argument before the conclusion.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Thesis paragraph: While many argue that social media connects people across distances, its overall effect on face-to-face relationships is largely negative. This essay will show that reduced attention spans, superficial interaction, and constant comparison outweigh its benefits for connection.

Quick check · multiple choice

What distinguishes an opinion essay from a blog post at Higher Level?

- A It cannot express any personal opinion
- B It requires a clear thesis and structured argument with a counter-argument
- C It must be written only in the past tense
- D It has no paragraphs

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Write an argumentative essay of 450-600 words responding to the statement: [25]
'Schools should replace all written homework with project-based learning.' State your position clearly and address at least one counter-argument.

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [25]

A high-scoring essay includes:

- An introduction with a clear thesis stating the writer's position
- Two or three body paragraphs, each opening with a clear topic sentence and one main argument, developed with reasoning or a specific example
- A paragraph acknowledging a counter-argument, such as 'Some argue that written homework builds independent study skills', before responding to it
- Cohesive devices linking ideas across and within paragraphs, such as furthermore, in contrast, as a result
- A conclusion that restates the thesis without simply repeating the introduction word for word
- Formal-to-semi-formal register maintained throughout, with varied and precise vocabulary
- Word count within 450-600 words

Quick check answer

B. The opinion essay needs an explicit thesis, logically developed arguments, and acknowledgment of an opposing view.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

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